

The Complete Guide to English Tenses

Definitions, Formulas, Examples, and Practice Exercises

Generated by your AI Assistant

Present Tense

Simple Present

Definition:	Used for facts, generalizations, and habitual actions.
Formula:	Subject + V1 (s/es) + Object
Example:	She writes a letter. / The sun rises in the east.

Present Continuous

Definition:	Used for actions happening right now or temporary situations.
Formula:	Subject + is/am/are + V1(-ing) + Object
Example:	She is writing a letter right now.

Present Perfect

Definition:	Used for actions completed recently or experience where time is not specified.
Formula:	Subject + has/have + V3 + Object
Example:	She has written a letter.

Present Perfect Continuous

Definition:	Used for actions that started in the past and are still continuing.
Formula:	Subject + has/have + been + V1(-ing) + Object
Example:	She has been writing a letter for two hours.

Past Tense

Simple Past

Definition:	Used for actions completed at a specific time in the past.
Formula:	Subject + V2 + Object
Example:	She wrote a letter yesterday.

Past Continuous

Definition:	Used for actions that were ongoing at a specific moment in the past.
Formula:	Subject + was/were + V1(-ing) + Object
Example:	She was writing a letter when I called.

Past Perfect

Definition:	Used for an action that was completed before another action in the past.
Formula:	Subject + had + V3 + Object
Example:	She had written the letter before he arrived.

Past Perfect Continuous

Definition:	Used to show that an action started in the past and continued up to another point in the past.
Formula:	Subject + had + been + V1(-ing) + Object
Example:	She had been writing for an hour when the power went out.

Future Tense

Simple Future

Definition:	Used for actions that will happen in the future.
Formula:	Subject + will/shall + V1 + Object
Example:	She will write a letter tomorrow.

Future Continuous

Definition:	Used for actions that will be in progress at a specific time in the future.
Formula:	Subject + will + be + V1(-ing) + Object
Example:	She will be writing a letter at 5 PM.

Future Perfect

Definition:	Used for actions that will be completed by a certain time in the future.
Formula:	Subject + will + have + V3 + Object
Example:	She will have written the letter by evening.

Future Perfect Continuous

Definition:	Used to emphasize the duration of an action up to a certain point in the future.
Formula:	Subject + will + have + been + V1(-ing) + Object
Example:	She will have been writing for three hours by the time you arrive.

Practice Exercises

Identify the tense or fill in the correct form of the verb:

1. I _____ (go) to the gym every morning. (Simple Present)
2. Look! The bird _____ (fly) away. (Present Continuous)
3. She _____ (finish) her homework already. (Present Perfect)
4. They _____ (live) in this city for ten years. (Present Perfect Continuous)
5. We _____ (watch) a movie yesterday. (Simple Past)
6. I _____ (sleep) when the phone rang. (Past Continuous)
7. The train _____ (leave) before we reached the station. (Past Perfect)
8. He _____ (work) there for 5 years before he quit. (Past Perfect Continuous)
9. I _____ (call) you tomorrow. (Simple Future)
10. At 8 PM tonight, I _____ (eat) dinner. (Future Continuous)
11. By next year, we _____ (complete) the project. (Future Perfect)
12. By 2030, she _____ (teach) for 20 years. (Future Perfect Continuous)

Answer Key:

1. go
2. is flying
3. has finished
4. have been living
5. watched
6. was sleeping
7. had left
8. had been working
9. will call
10. will be eating
11. will have completed
12. will have been teaching